

The Next Decade in Tech: Context, Ubiquity and the Cloud

It seemed somehow appropriate to be asked to write this column while at the 2011 Korea World IT Show, standing in the shadow of 75-inch smart TVs and bathed in 4G LTE wireless. One thing that seems unlikely to change in the next decade is our mutual obsession with extremes: the biggest TV, the fastest broadband, the slimmest tablet.

Arguably the key theme behind all of those obsessions is how we access information: the speed at which we can do it, the convenience, the context in which it is presented. Futurologists of decades past predicted flying cars, supersonic transport being commonplace and a videophone on every wall and in every pocket. Although that may seem parochial today, at their core such suggestions also deal with the increasing pace of information. A faster car or plane to take you to your face-to-face meetings, a videophone to give the impression of presence when you can't be there yourself.

Their view of the future was colored by their pre-internet lives; our own predictions will perhaps be more accurate, given our place at this digital tipping point. We've taken Facebook and Twitter to heart – we don't need to be in the same room as someone to wish them a happy birthday – and we've already begun to take those social networking services in our pocket. Our phones and tablets allow us a mobile window into our online lifestyles, the gadgets themselves perpetually getting faster, more portable, more feature-rich.

What will change in the coming decade is context. Facebook on your mobile today is the same as on your desktop browser, simply smaller; it takes no account of where you are, or whether your information needs may be different based on the situation you find yourself in. That will require mobile devices with sufficient processing power and bandwidth to crunch hard data like location, time and date, along with fuzzier contexts like who you are with, what form

you might want your data presented in, what inferences you might be looking for. Expect phones to create ad-hoc, mesh networks, invisibly communicating with each other so as to educate the context, sharing the masses of data stored no longer on USB drives in our pockets or flash memory in our gadgets, but on wireless storage.

The past ten years have seen greater value placed on “the cloud”: pushing our

data to communal servers and accessing it via ever-fattening pipes rather than carrying content with us. That's only likely to accelerate, as media costs fall, wireless connections become faster and more ubiquitous, and people begin to expect consistent access to more and more of their files. As that reliance grows, the cloud will increasingly be the backbone to our social lives, the concept of “sharing” “spreading” to every gadget and service we use.

We're already seeing a backlash against the cloud, however, punctuated with embarrassing mistakes by companies we'd thought would know better. Amazon's EC2 downtime – resulting in irretrievable data loss for some customers – was a wake-up call that, just because a server network is big, it doesn't mean it's infallible. Sony's recent PlayStation Network fiasco, with millions of stolen user records, underscored quite how much we rely on the precautions of others, and that reputation isn't necessarily a cast-iron guarantee that they're doing the right thing with our data.

Those storm clouds are unlikely to be the last, but then neither is the cloud itself going anywhere. The next decade will see remote servers come of age, but so will hard-learned expectations of data responsibility and, most likely, increased liability for those that don't take care of it as they have been charged with. Expect privacy concerns to make headlines again and again, as we attempt to balance our desire to share with our innate caution over our digital identities.

Of course, the one certainty is that ten years from now I'll look back on these predictions and laugh: they'll likely seem as hopelessly naïve as “kitchen of the future” videos from the 1950s, suggesting we'll have robot housemaids. Technology has the capacity to delight and confuse us, reassure and mislead us in equal measure. No matter what the next decade has in store, it won't be dull. 



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